safety of the mountains. It was a difficult beginning, but the small group began to grow in ranks, recruiting new members among dissatisfied Cuban urban youth and local peasants.

Batista's regime used ever more brutal tactics to suppress the rebels, but that only increased the number of fighters. Those measures also tarnished the image of the regime abroad, turning US public opinion against the Cuban dictator. The US government was obliged to recall its ambassador to Havana and impose a trade embargo on Cuba, which stopped the sale of arms to Batista and gave a huge boost to the rebels. The year 1958, when arms sales ceased, became a turning point in the Castro-led revolution. After suffering a major defeat at the hands of government forces in the summer, Castro managed to regroup and launch his own offensive. On December 31, the diverse rebel groups came together in a battle for Santa Clara, taking the city and causing enough panic in Havana to make Batista flee the country.

With the dictator gone, resistance to the revolutionary forces, which had been all but wiped out only half a year earlier, collapsed. Castro staged a victory march on Havana, already in rebel hands, and entered the city on January 8, 1959. He was not about to repeat the mistakes of Batista, who had released him from prison under international pressure. Enemies of the regime would be punished mercilessly, whatever the world might say about it. Hundreds of old-regime officials were dismissed and put on trial, and close to two hundred were executed by firing squad. Leading figures of the new regime, Raúl Castro and Che Guevara conducted purges and persecuted enemies. A corrupt and highly unpopular dictator was gone, replaced by a presumably incorruptible and charismatic new one.

The Cuban revolution had succeeded, but what that meant was not yet clear either to its leaders or to its supporters and opponents, both in Cuba and abroad. Direct American investment increased during the first year of Castro's rule, but that changed quickly as the government embarked on badly needed agrarian reform. In May 1959 Castro limited the size of agricultural estates to one thousand acres; the rest were to be confiscated and redistributed by the government without compensation to the landowners. In July 1960 the government nationalized all US-owned businesses and properties: since the revolutionary government needed resources and lacked money, no compensation was offered for the